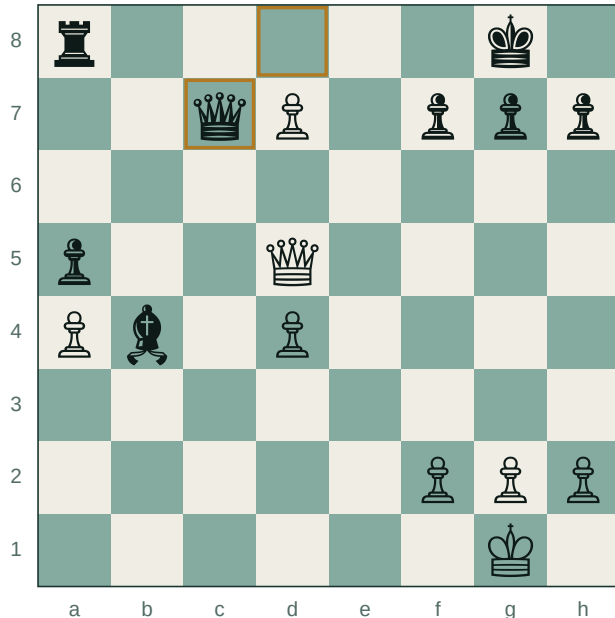


Loose-piece tactics: White, move 27

Loose-piece tactics

White to move



Previous move: 26...Qxc7. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

27. Qxa8+ Bf8 28. Qc8 Qxd7 29. Qxd7

27.Qxa8+ Check restricts Black to 4 legal replies here. The move also takes the rook on a8. Recorded reply: **27...Bf8**.

28.Qc8 The queen moves from a8 to c8. From c8 it attacks queen on c7 and bishop on f8. Recorded reply: **28...Qxd7**.

29.Qxd7 The queen captures the queen on d7.

At the end, nominal material is White 14 / Black 7 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +13. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +13: the balance goes from -6 to +7. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A piece may appear hanging because its defender is indirect: taking it might allow mate, a fork, or a stronger capture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An undefended or tactically undefendable piece can turn an ordinary position into a combination. The first task is to distinguish a truly free capture from a poisoned one.

HOW TO LOOK

List the loose enemy pieces and check whether a forcing move can expose or attack more than one of them.

The defending king is on g8. Absolute pin: pawn on f7.